After the conclusion of the Chinese Civil War in 1949, the People's Republic of China made clear its intent of spreading the revolution to 'all the territory of China' including Tibet. By then, however, the Chinese Nationalist mission in Lhasa had been expelled by Tibetan authorities, seeming to strengthen the case for Tibetan independence. That did not prevent the PLA from invading Tibet in 1950 to reverse what it saw as national humiliation, access Tibetan natural resources, and consolidate its precarious hold on the western province of Xinjiang. In the 1951 agreement in which Tibet ceded its independence to China, Beijing agreed to respect Tibet's cultural and religious autonomy. [82]

Thus, beginning in 1950–1951, for the first time, India and China shared a direct border as independent and sovereign states. Although Indian leaders expressed initial concern and hesitation about recognizing Chinese control of Tibet, India's ambassador K.M. Panikkar appeared to have conceded the reality when he presented credentials to the new Chinese government. In New Delhi, it was generally felt that India did not have the military resources to help Tibet retain its status as a buffer state. [83] But concerns grew about securing the border from the new potential threat. A little over a month before his death, Sardar Patel wrote to Nehru on 7 November 1950 cautioning about Chinese intentions: 'The Chinese Government has tried to delude us by professions of peaceful intention . . . even though we regard ourselves as the friends of China, the Chinese do not regard us as their friends . . . In my judgement the situation is one which we cannot afford either to be complacent or to be vacillating.' [84] A few days later, on 18 November, Nehru—while acknowledging the new realities—issued a note suggesting a different view of Beijing's predisposition: '[T]here is, in my opinion, practically no chance of a major attack on India by China . . . The idea that . . . Chinese communism means inevitably an expansion towards India, is rather naive.' [85]

Meanwhile, concerns also grew in Indian military and intelligence circles. The Himmatsinhji Committee—composed of military, intelligence, diplomatic, and defence officials—examined the consequences of China's invasion of Tibet on the frontier regions, producing reports in April and